

rigorous investigations for almost 18 months, comparing technologies based on CAPEX, OPEX, maintenance, robustness, the integration framework and adaptability. Our evaluations of CAPEX showed that expenditure on proprietary software would be 30 per cent higher than open source options. The OPEX was also less for open source,” says Sujeet Kumar, manager, IT. Furthermore, LifeSpring did not want to assign dedicated staff to manage IT at every hospital unit. The availability of trusted support vendors like Red Hat cemented the hospital’s confidence in open source technology, and led to its decision to stay away from proprietary software.

A mixed bag

Getting the right mix of software applications for its needs was essential for LifeSpring to reap maximum benefits from open source technology. The company began by choosing Red Hat’s robust open source solutions, as Red Hat could provide reliable support for its software framework. Thereafter, the hunt for the right OSS mix began. “Flexibility, community support, and compatibility with our needs were some of the criteria we used to select our OSS application basket. We also considered Red Hat’s extensive ISV catalogue, to ensure that we chose Red Hat Enterprise Linux-certified products,” says Kumar.

JBoss Enterprise Application Platform was the first to make it into the open source basket for LifeSpring. “We chose JBoss as it was the principal requirement for our HIMS (hospital information management system), which is built on Java and MySQL. The large community support and superb features, such as clustering, fail-over, load balancing and proxies, made it absolutely essential for our

HIMS,” says Kumar. Additionally, LifeSpring chose Zimbra for its mailing needs, since Zimbra offered much better features and services, compared to any other open source or proprietary option. “Zimbra goes beyond just being a mailing solution. It is a complete collaboration suite, with features like a document management system and task management system, which led us to choose it over other options in the market,” says Kumar.

Strong community support and their range of features is what made LifeSpring select Moodle and Elastix. “Moodle is used by leading universities as their learning management system. We chose Elastix as it integrates the best tools available for Asterisk-based PBXs into a single, easy-to-use interface. Both these applications also have strong and active community support,” says Kumar.

The open source trouble-ticketing system was in alignment with LifeSpring’s business needs. “It was very easy to configure for our not-so-tech-savvy staff. Power users could easily start a queue or work-flow themselves,” says Kumar. Alfresco, on the other hand, provided the hospital chain with out-of-the-box portal integration and full content control, with integrated document management, security, document status and work-flow management. In fact, Alfresco turned its filing system into a simple-to-use, compliant, auditable document repository. Lastly, LifeSpring chose Zabbix for monitoring, as it was the most complete tool on offer. “While deciding on the monitoring tool, we had the options of Zenoss, Nagios and Zabbix. We chose Zabbix because it has several tools that are left out of Nagios. Also, Zabbix is better for data collection, and it is one centralised solution compared to Nagios and Zenoss,” says Kumar.



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